“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 19

The Divine Madness of Śrī Caitanya

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I bow down to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, the crown jewel of all who are devoted to their mothers. Raving in divine madness, He rubbed His face against the walls; and He sported in the spring garden.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 In this way Mahāprabhu, absorbed in love for Kṛṣṇa, spoke the ravings of divine madness night and day.

4 Jagadānanda Paṇḍita was very dear to the Lord, and the Lord took joy in his conduct.

5 Every year the Lord sent him to Nadia to console His mother, for He knew how she grieved in separation from Him.

6 “Go to Nadia and convey My obeisances to Mother. Touch her lotus feet on My behalf.

7 Tell her: ‘Please remember — every day I come and bow at your feet.

8 On any day you wish to feed Me, I certainly come and eat.

9 I gave up serving you and took *sannyāsa*. I became a madman and abandoned My duty.

10 Do not hold this offence against Me. I am dependent on you — I am your son.

11 I stay in Nīlācala by your order, and as long as I live I cannot leave it.' "

12 The cloth *prasāda* that the Lord received at the festival of Jagannātha's cowherd pastime He sent to His mother at the request of Paramānanda Purī.

13 He also took care to obtain the best of Jagannātha's *prasāda*, and He sent it separately to His mother and to the devotees.

14 The Lord is the crown jewel of all who are devoted to their mothers. Even after taking *sannyāsa*, He always served His mother.

15 Jagadānanda went to Nadia, met the Lord's mother and told her all the Lord's messages.

16 He met Advaita Ācārya and the other devotees and gave them *prasāda*. After staying a month, he took leave of the Lord's mother.

17 He went to the Ācārya to take leave of him, and Ācārya Gosāñi gave him a message for the Lord.

18 The Ācārya spoke a riddle in the form of a *tarjā* (*tarjā-prahelī*), full of hints, which only the Lord could understand; no one else could.

19 "Convey my countless obeisances to the Lord, and lay this submission of mine at His feet:

20 Tell the madman (*bāul*) that the people have gone mad. Tell the madman that rice no longer sells in the market.

21 Tell the madman that the *āul* — the one mad with love — is no longer engaged in worldly affairs. Tell the madman that a madman has said this."

22 Hearing this, Jagadānanda began to laugh. Then he returned to Nīlācala and told it to the Lord.

23 Hearing the *tarjā*, Mahāprabhu smiled slightly and said, "That is his order." Then He fell silent.

24 Learning of this, Svarūpa Gosāñi asked the Lord, "I could not understand the meaning of this *tarjā*."[1]

25 The Lord said, "The Ācārya is a great worshipper, expert in the rules and regulations of the Āgama scriptures.

26 For worship he invokes the Deity, and for the worship he keeps the Deity present for some time.

27 When the worship is completed, he then sends the Deity away. I do not know the meaning of the *tarjā*, or what is in his mind.

28 The Ācārya is a great master of mystic power, skilled in *tarjās*. Even I cannot understand the meaning of his *tarjā*."

29 Hearing this, all the devotees were astonished, and Svarūpa Gosāñi became somewhat downcast.

30 From that day the Lord's condition changed: His feeling of separation from Kṛṣṇa grew twice as strong.

31 Night and day He behaved and raved like one mad. Absorbed in the feelings of Rādhā, He felt the separation grow every moment.

32 Suddenly Kṛṣṇa's departure for Mathurā appeared before Him, and the state of *udghūrṇā*, a symptom of divine madness, arose in Him.

33 Holding Rāmānanda by the neck, He raved, and He questioned Svarūpa, taking him for one of His own friends (*sakhīs*).

34 Reciting the verse with which Rādhikā once questioned Viśākhā, He began to rave:

35 "O friend, where is Kṛṣṇa, the moon of Nanda's dynasty, adorned with peacock feathers? Where is He whose flute sounds so deep, whose luster is like the sapphire? Where is He who dances in the rapture of the *rāsa*? Where is He — My treasure, the medicine that saves My life, My dearest friend? Alas! Alas! Fie on the Creator!" (Lalita-mādhava, 3.25)

36 "The dynasty of the king of Vraja is an ocean of milk, and Kṛṣṇa, born in it like the full moon, has lit up the world. The eyes of the people of Vraja are *cakora* birds: they drink the nectar of His luster constantly, and only by drinking it do they live.

37 O friend, where is Kṛṣṇa? Let Me see Him! If I do not see His face even for a moment, My heart breaks. Show Him to Me quickly, or My life will not remain.

38 The women of Vraja are night-blooming lotuses scorched by the sun of loving desire (*kāma*). Where is that moon of Mine who makes them blossom with the gift of the nectar of His rays — His hands? O friend, show Him to Me and save My life!

39 Where is the beauty of His crown, with its waving peacock feathers, like a rainbow in a fresh cloud? His yellow garment is a flash of lightning, His pearl necklace a line of herons, and His dark body surpasses a fresh rain cloud.

40 Once Kṛṣṇa's body catches someone's eye, it stays awake in that heart forever, like the sap of the mango tree. It enters the minds of women and will not come out, however hard they try. It is not a body — it is a thorn of the *seyākul* bush!

41 His luster surpasses the luster of the *tamāla* tree, it is like the sapphire, and with that luster He maddens the world. Surely the Creator fashioned Him by straining out the very essence of the *rasa* of love and mixing it with moonlight.

42 Where is the sound of that flute which surpasses the thunder of a fresh cloud and draws the whole world to hear it? At its sound the people of Vraja rise and run like thirsty *cātaka* birds, and come to drink the streams of the nectar of His luster.

43 He is My moon, the treasury of all arts, the great medicine that saves My life. O friend, He is My dearest friend. Yet My body lives on without Him — fie on such a life! What a mockery the Creator has made of Me!

44 "Why does he make one live who does not want to live?" — so anger and grief rose in Him against the Creator. Reciting a verse from the *Bhāgavatam*, He rebuked the Creator and reproached Kṛṣṇa:

45 "O Creator, there is no mercy in you anywhere! You join embodied beings in friendship and love, and then, before their desires are fulfilled, you pointlessly separate them. Your doings are like the play of a child." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 10.39.19)

46 “You do not know the heart of love, and you labour in vain. Your doings are like a child’s. If I can only get hold of you, I will teach you such a lesson that you will never arrange such things again!

47 O Creator, you are very cruel! You bring together in love those who are so hard for each other to win. Why then do you part them before their desires are fulfilled?

48 O merciless Creator! You showed Me Kṛṣṇa’s face and tempted My eyes and mind. I had drunk it for only a moment when you snatched it away and took it elsewhere. You have committed the sin of taking back what you gave.

49 If you say, villain, ‘It is Akrūra who has wronged you — why are you angry with me?’ — then know that it was you who took the form of Akrūra and stole Kṛṣṇa away. No one else behaves like this.

50 But it is the fault of My own deeds — why should I be angry with you? You and I have nothing to do with each other. It is Kṛṣṇa, the Lord of My life, with whom I lived together, who has become so cruel!

51 He whom I serve, having given up everything for Him, kills Me with His own hand. Kṛṣṇa has no fear of killing a woman. I am dying for Him, yet Hari will not even turn back to look at Me. In a moment He has broken our love.

52 But why should I be angry with Kṛṣṇa? It is the fault of My own ill fate: the fruit of My sins has ripened. Kṛṣṇa, who is subject to My love, has been made indifferent to Me — so mighty is My misfortune!”

53 In this way Gaura Rāya cried in grief, “Alas! Alas! O Kṛṣṇa, where have You gone?” With the feelings of the *gopīs* in His heart, He lamented in their words: “O Govinda! O Dāmodara! O Mādhava!”

54 Then Svarūpa and Rāmānanda Rāya tried in various ways to console Mahāprabhu. They sang auspicious songs and turned the Lord's mind, and His mind grew somewhat calm.

55 In this way half the night passed in His ravings. Then Svarūpa Gosāñi put the Lord to bed in the Gambhīrā.

56 After putting the Lord to bed, Rāmānanda went home, and Svarūpa and Govinda lay down at the door of the Gambhīrā.

57 Mahāprabhu's mind was overflowing with love, and He stayed awake chanting the holy name.

58 Agitated by separation, the Lord rose in distress and began to rub His face against the walls of the Gambhīrā.

59 Countless wounds appeared on His face, cheeks and nose, and blood streamed from them, but the Lord, absorbed in feeling, did not know it.

60 All night, in ecstasy, He rubbed His face and made sounds like "goṅ-goṅ." Then Svarūpa heard Him.

61 They lit a lamp and went into the room, and when Svarūpa and Govinda saw the Lord's face, they were both deeply grieved.

62 They brought the Lord to His bed and made Him lie down, and Svarūpa asked, "Why did You do this?"

63 The Lord said, "In My distress I could not stay in the room. I wandered about looking for the door, to get out quickly.

64 Not finding the door, I struck My face against the walls on every side. I was wounded and blood flowed, but I could not get out."

65 In the state of divine madness the Lord's mind was never steady. Whatever He did and whatever He said was a symptom of that madness.

66 Then Svarūpa Gosāñi became anxious, and the next day he gathered the devotees and took counsel with them.

67 All the devotees together entreated the Lord, and they had Śaṅkara Paṇḍita sleep with Him.

68 Śaṅkara lay at the Lord's feet, and the Lord would stretch His feet out over him.

69 So he became known as "the pillow for the Lord's feet," just as Śrī Śuka once described Vidura:

70 "When the humble Vidura, the pillow for the feet of the thousand-headed Lord, had spoken thus, the sage Maitreya, urged on to speak of Bhagavān, his hairs standing on end with joy, began his account." (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 3.13.5)

71 Śaṅkara would massage the Lord's feet, fall asleep and lie there just as he was.

72 When Śaṅkara lay asleep with his body uncovered, the Lord would rise and wrap him in His own quilt.

73 Śaṅkara would keep falling asleep but quickly wake again, and then he would sit up, press the Lord's feet, and stay awake through the night.

74 Because of him the Lord could not go out, nor could He rub His lotus face against the walls.

75 Raghunātha dāsa has described this pastime of Mahāprabhu in his *Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa*:

76 “In separation from His Vraja, which He held as dear as millions of lives, He was bewildered in mind and raved constantly in His madness. Ceaselessly rubbing His moonlike face against the wall, He left on it the blood that flowed from His wounds. That Gaurāṅga, rising in my heart, makes me mad with joy.” (Caitanya-stava-kalpavṛkṣa, 6)

77 In this way, night and day, Mahāprabhu remained immersed in the ocean of love, now sinking, now rising to the surface.

78 Once, on the full-moon day of the month of Vaiśākha, Mahāprabhu went to a garden at night.

79 Taking the devotees with Him, the Lord entered the foremost of gardens, named Jagannātha-vallabha.

80 The trees and creepers were in full bloom, as in Vṛndāvana, and parrots — *śukas* and *śārīs* — cuckoos and bees were all conversing.

81 Carrying the fragrance of the flowers, the breeze from the Malaya hills blew, and like a teacher it taught the trees and creepers to dance.

82 Everything shone brightly in the light of the full moon; the trees, the creepers and all else glittered in the moonlight.

83 All six seasons were present there, with spring foremost among them. Seeing this, Gaura Bhagavān was delighted.

84 Having His associates sing the song “Lalita-lavaṅga-latā,” the Lord danced and roamed about with them.

85 Wandering in this way from tree to tree and creeper to creeper, He suddenly saw Kṛṣṇa beneath an *aśoka* tree.

86 Seeing Kṛṣṇa, Mahāprabhu ran towards Him, but Kṛṣṇa, seeing Him before Him, smiled and disappeared.

87 He had found Kṛṣṇa, only to lose Him again, and the Lord fell to the ground unconscious.

88 The garden was filled with the fragrance of Kṛṣṇa's holy body, and catching that fragrance, the Lord lost consciousness.

89 The fragrance of Kṛṣṇa entered His nostrils constantly, and as He relished it, the Lord went mad.

90 The Lord recited the verse that Rādhā, longing for Kṛṣṇa's fragrance, spoke to Her friend, and He explained its meaning:

91 "O friend, with waves of the fragrance of His body, which surpasses musk, He draws women to Him; from the eight lotuses of His body He spreads the fragrance of the lotus mixed with camphor; and He is anointed with a fragrant paste of musk, camphor, fine sandal and *aguru*. That Madana-mohana of Mine deepens the longing of My nostrils." (Govinda-līlāmṛta, 8.6)

92 "The fragrance of Kṛṣṇa's body surpasses the fragrance of musk and the blue lotus. It pervades the fourteen worlds, draws everyone, and makes the eyes of women blind.

93 O friend, Kṛṣṇa's fragrance maddens the world! It enters a woman's nostrils and stays there for ever; it seizes her and carries her away to Kṛṣṇa's side.

94 His eyes, navel, face, hands and feet are the eight lotuses on Kṛṣṇa's body. The fragrance of a lotus anointed with camphor — that is the fragrance of those eight lotuses.

95 Sandalwood set in gold is ground, and *aguru*, *kuṅkuma*, musk and camphor are mixed with it; this paste is applied to His body, and mingling with the body's own fragrance, it seems to steal it away and hide it.

96 The fragrance of Kṛṣṇa's body steals the bodies and minds of women; it sets their nostrils reeling, loosens the knots of their garments and undoes their braided hair. First it drives the women of the world mad, and then it makes them dance — such a robber is the fragrance of Kṛṣṇa's body!

97 The nostrils conquered by that fragrance always long for it. Sometimes they get it and sometimes not. When they get it, they drink their fill and still cry, 'More! More!' When they do not, they die of thirst.

98 Madana-mohana, the actor, has opened a market of fragrance and tempts the women of the world to come as customers. He gives the fragrance free of charge, but having given it, He makes them blind, and they cannot find their way home."

99 In this way the fragrance stole the mind of Gaurahari, and He ran here and there like a bee. He went to the trees and creepers in the hope that Kṛṣṇa would appear, but He did not find Kṛṣṇa — He found only His fragrance.

100 Svarūpa and Rāmānanda sang, and the Lord danced and was happy. In this way morning came. Then, by various means, Svarūpa and Rāmānanda Rāya brought Mahāprabhu back to external awareness.

101 His devotion to His mother, His ravings, His rubbing His face against the walls, and His divine dancing when the fragrance of Kṛṣṇa appeared to

Him — these four pastimes Kṛṣṇadāsa, the servant of Rūpa Gosāñi, has sung in this chapter.

102 Having thus regained consciousness, Mahāprabhu bathed and went to see Lord Jagannātha.

103 Kṛṣṇa's pastimes are unearthly, and divine is their power; His conduct lies beyond the reach of reasoning.

104 Even scholars cannot understand the behaviour of one in whose heart this love is always awake.

105 "The ways of the fortunate soul in whose heart this new *prema* has blossomed are very hard to understand, even for those who know the scriptures." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.4.17)

106 When you hear of the Lord's unearthly behaviour and ravings, do not argue — hear with faith.

107 Evidence of their truth is found in the *Śrī Bhāgavatam*: the ravings of Śrī Rādhā in the *Bhramara-gītā*.

108 So too are the songs of the queens at the end of the Tenth Canto, whose special meaning scholars do not understand.

109 One on whom Mahāprabhu and Nityānanda, or the servant of Their servant, bestow Their mercy has faith in this.

110 Hear this with faith — there is great joy in hearing it. It will destroy the threefold miseries, beginning with those of body and mind, and the pain of false arguments.

111 The *Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta* is ever new. As one hears it again and again, the heart and the ears are soothed.

112 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. So in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition: *jāniyā* (“learning [of this]”). Other editions read *jāniyāo*, “though he knew [the meaning]”: “Though Svarūpa Gosāñi knew it, he still asked.” ↩